



176 Look Ma!



184 Dawn Of War



210 No Blocking This Ad!

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Lead Feature

Agent 002?

On the hunt for another universe

Agent001

How would you like to escape this world to one where you're as good-looking as you want to be, can create things out of thin air, and more importantly—fly? Since 2003, Linden Labs' *Second Life* has been offering its users just that. It enjoyed its low profile for around two years, but this year saw a tremendous jump both in user count and coverage in the media—so much so that you even have reporters interviewing each other about it! The reporters in question, incidentally, are CNET's Daniel Terdiman and Reuters' Adam Pasick—both responsible for the

news desks that their respective employers have set up *inside* Second Life.

What Is It?

Second Life (SL) is exactly what its name suggests—an alternative life. It lets you do pretty much what you would do in your real life—meet people, work to earn money, buy land, build homes on land, sell said homes for profit—a detailed 3D simulation of society itself, only more controlled.

The internal currency is the Linden dollar, which you can either earn in-game by providing services, or by buying Linden dollars in exchange for real US dollars—the exchange rate as of this writing

is 271 Linden dollars to the US dollar, and this gap is slowly bridging. Technology companies, with their keen abilities to go where the people are, have also seen the potential of this universe, and big names like Sun, IBM, and Dell have already set up shop and are spending considerable time and effort spreading their propaganda. You can even cough up Linden dollars for your spanking new Dell laptop (the kind you use in real life).

Following the insane levels of hype, I decided to give

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